

Regular Employee Handbook and Operational Policy

ACCESS LEVEL: STAFF / EMPLOYEE TIER

TIER 2 - EMPLOYEE

Welcome to the NovaTech Staff Portal. This document outlines core policies regarding employee benefits, performance expectations, workplace standards, and operational workflows applicable to all full-time and part-time permanent staff members across global operations.

1. Employee Benefits

NovaTech offers a comprehensive benefits package designed to support staff health, financial security, and personal balance. Full-time employees become eligible for core benefits starting on their first day of official employment.

- **Medical, Dental & Vision:** Comprehensive group coverage with 85% employer-paid premiums.
- **Retirement Matching:** 401(k) / pension matching up to 5% of base salary, fully vested immediately.
- **Learning Allowance:** Annual individual stipend of \$1,500 for technical courses, certifications, and conferences.
- **Wellness Stipend:** \$75 monthly allowance for fitness memberships, ergonomic equipment, or mental health apps.
- **Employee Assistance Program (EAP):** Free, confidential 24/7 counseling and legal consultation services.

2. Leave Policy

Full-time employees receive a structured time-off package designed to encourage adequate rest and work-life harmony. Standard staff accrue 20 days of Paid Time Off (PTO) per calendar year, accrued on a bi-weekly payroll basis.

In addition to standard PTO allocations, staff are entitled to:

- 10 paid statutory public holidays observed annually.
- 10 days of fully paid sick leave per year for personal illness or family care.
- Up to 12 weeks of fully paid parental leave for primary and secondary caregivers following birth or adoption.

PTO requests exceeding 3 consecutive business days must be submitted through the HR System at least 2 weeks in advance for supervisor review. Unused PTO may be carried over into the next calendar year up to a maximum cap of 5 days.

Access Control Overlay: Unlike interns who accrue 6 days max per term, regular employees receive 20 days PTO plus 10 sick days. Managerial approval metrics are detailed in Tier 3 docs.

3. Work From Home

NovaTech operates on a flexible hybrid work model. Regular full-time employees are permitted to work remotely up to 2 days per week (typically Tuesdays and Thursdays), with remaining days spent on-site in their assigned office location.

Full-time staff may also request temporary fully remote arrangements (up to 3 consecutive weeks per calendar year) for remote work within domestic boundaries. Remote work requires a high-speed internet connection and mandatory compliance with IT security guidelines, including corporate VPN and MFA authentication.

5. Performance Reviews

Employee performance is evaluated biannually through structured Mid-Year (July) and Year-End (December) performance cycles. Reviews assess individual output against quarterly OKRs (Objectives and Key Results), team collaboration, and adherence to company values.

The review workflow incorporates self-evaluations, peer feedback from 3 to 5 cross-functional colleagues, and a direct manager appraisal. Final performance ratings directly influence annual merit salary increases, performance bonus calculations, and promotion eligibility.

6. Training & Career Growth

Continuous learning is integral to NovaTech's culture. Beyond the individual \$1,500 learning stipend, staff have unlimited access to internal technical workshops, architecture training, and leadership pathways.

Employees are encouraged to allocate up to 10% of their working hours (approximately 4 hours per week) toward self-directed skill enhancement, internal hackathons, or open-source projects supported by the company.

7. Travel and Expenses

Employees traveling on authorized company business are entitled to full reimbursement for reasonable travel, lodging, and meal expenses under corporate expense policies.

- **Airfare & Rail:** Bookings must be made in Economy class via the corporate travel portal at least 14 days in advance.
- **Lodging:** Standard hotel rooms capped at \$220/night in major domestic markets (\$300/night in premium locations).
- **Meals & Incidental:** Daily meal allowance capped at \$75/day. Itemized receipts are mandatory for expenses over \$25.
- **Submission:** Expense reports must be submitted through the finance portal within 30 days of travel completion.

8. Workplace Conduct & Compliance

All staff are required to maintain high standards of professional ethics, respect, and compliance. NovaTech enforces a zero-tolerance policy regarding workplace harassment, discrimination, or retaliation.

Employees must complete annual mandatory compliance modules covering Information Security, Data Protection (GDPR/CCPA compliance), Anti-Bribery policies, and Conflict of Interest disclosures. Violations are investigated by HR and may lead to disciplinary measures up to termination.

9. Promotion Process

Promotions are evaluated during biannual review cycles based on demonstrated performance at the targeted job level, business unit requirements, and leadership growth. The standard promotion path requires two consecutive review cycles of "Exceeds Expectations" ratings, a detailed dossier submitted by the direct manager, and department head approval.

10. Strategic Direction Overview

At a high level, NovaTech's operational focus centers on expanding our enterprise software footprint, increasing recurring subscription revenue, and delivering high platform reliability (99.99% uptime target). Detailed roadmap goals, financial targets, and departmental budgets are restricted to management and board level documentation.